

Who Wins the World Cup?

A Monte Carlo simulation of the 48-team tournament, driven by World Football Elo ratings and xG-adjusted match outcomes.

TITLE FAVOURITE

Spain

21.7% to win

CLOSEST CHALLENGER

Argentina

20.7% to win

FIELD

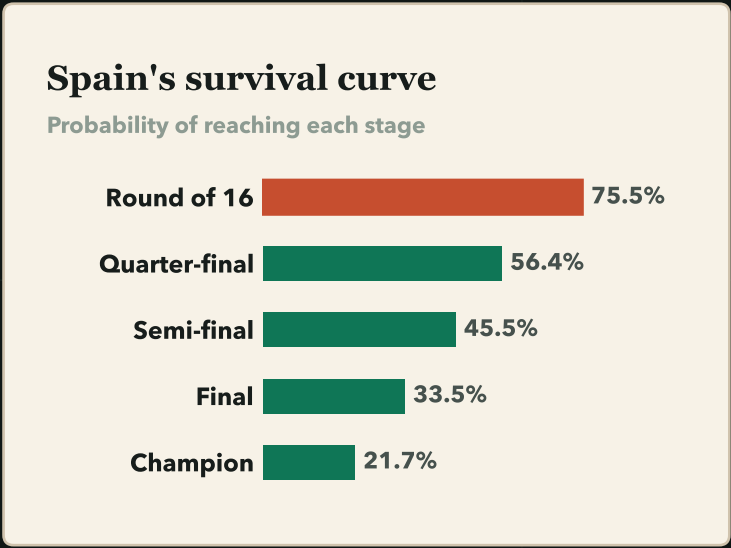
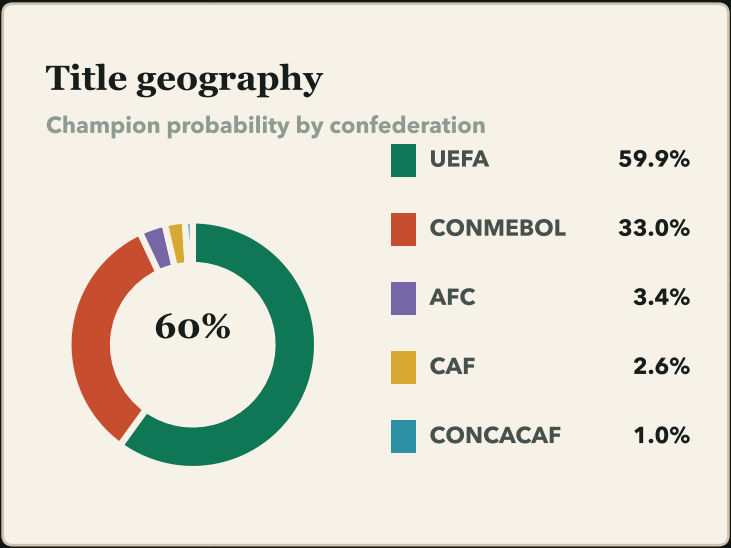
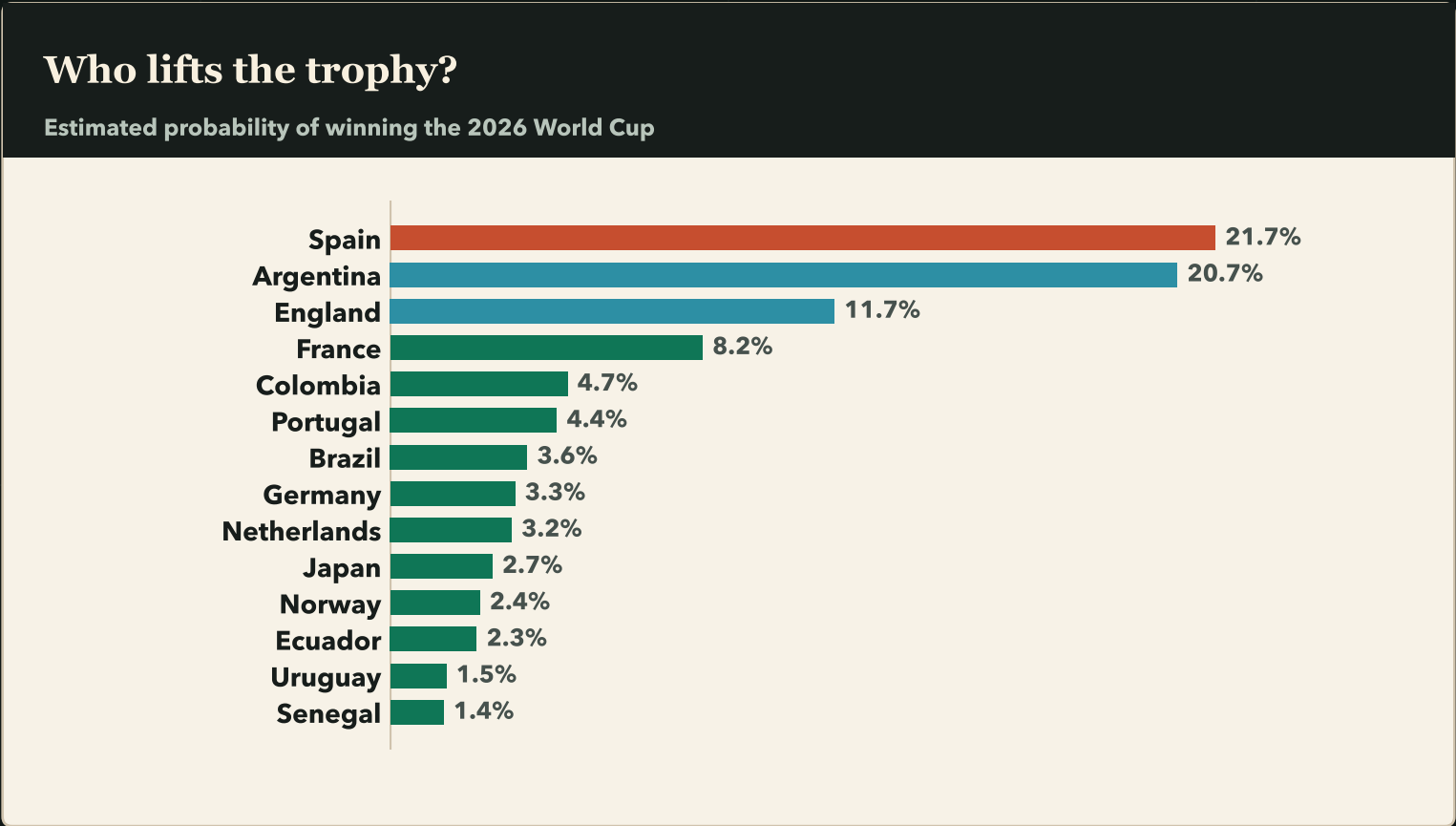
48 teams

12 groups of four

SIMULATIONS

10,000

as of June 9, 2026



The Path Through the Bracket

Each team's chance of surviving to the round of 16, quarter-finals, semi-finals, final and title.

Knockout pressure map

Probability of reaching each stage. Darker means more likely.

	Round of 16	Quarter	Semi	Final	Win
1 Spain	76%	56%	46%	33%	22%
2 Argentina	70%	59%	44%	31%	21%
3 England	72%	52%	35%	20%	12%
4 France	70%	47%	30%	16%	8.2%
5 Colombia	60%	36%	19%	10.0%	4.7%
6 Portugal	60%	35%	19%	9.7%	4.4%
7 Brazil	59%	35%	19%	8.5%	3.6%
8 Germany	62%	33%	18%	7.6%	3.3%
9 Netherlands	55%	34%	17%	7.5%	3.2%
10 Japan	51%	31%	15%	6.8%	2.7%
11 Norway	53%	28%	14%	5.7%	2.4%
12 Ecuador	56%	28%	14%	6.0%	2.3%
13 Uruguay	38%	21%	11%	4.4%	1.5%
14 Senegal	45%	22%	9.9%	4.0%	1.4%

Group favourites

Two most likely sides to advance from each group.

GROUP A Mexico47% South Korea39%	GROUP B Switzerland60% Canada48%	GROUP C Brazil59% Morocco43%	GROUP D Turkey45% Paraguay34%
GROUP E Germany62% Ecuador56%	GROUP F Netherlands55% Japan51%	GROUP G Belgium56% Iran25%	GROUP H Spain76% Uruguay38%
GROUP I France70% Norway53%	GROUP J Argentina70% Austria26%	GROUP K Colombia60% Portugal60%	GROUP L England72% Croatia44%

Does the Model Actually Work?

Backtests replay each past tournament from its pre-tournament ratings and score the forecast.

Backtested under pressure

Re-running the model with pre-tournament ratings only – no hindsight.

WORLD CUP	ACTUAL CHAMPION	PRE-TOURNAMENT ODDS	RANK
2014	Germany	18.1%	#3
2018	France	5.7%	#5
2022	Argentina	21.8%	#2

Receipts

#3.3

average pre-tournament rank
the model gave the eventual winner

3/3

champions the model placed
inside its top five favourites

0.038

mean calibration error
(predicted vs. observed rates)